

EPISODE 1

"MAINLAND"

Written by

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1 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - LOCOS - DAY

1

The sound of wailing.

A family of GRIZZLY BEARS, one isolated: LUCINDA.

She's bolting from the kitchen, frantic, her husband FRANK lagging behind.

In one hand, her eldest, HAZEL; in her husband's arms, her loud newborn, LOUIS.

They rush down the orange glazed terracotta tiles of the foyer, past pink walls and antique couches, tall coat hangers and messy shoe racks.

Following is her mother, BELINDA, alongside her siblings and cousins.

Belinda parts her quivering lips, baring white-toothed fangs.

She snarls.

BELINDA

(bold)

It will all be for nothing. Nothing!

She gives chase.

2 EXT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - LOCOS - DAY

2

The family bursts out the front door to a 4x4 truck parked on a soak-stained concrete driveway.

In a flash, Lucinda VAULTS into the driver's seat. Her husband and kids pile into the back.

Already in the passenger's seat: RIVER, her older brother.

River's glancing straight at the road ahead.

He's grinding his teeth in apprehension.

RIVER

Take a right.

BELINDA

(yelling)

If you leave-

RIVER

Go, don't look, just go.

BELINDA

Then you leave forever, you hear me?

Lucinda fumbles with the keys. River brushes his nose.

BELINDA

River, out of the car, now! Get her out! Drag her if you have to!

Lucinda shoves the key in the lock and twists it.

The engine revs.

She SLAMS on the accelerator.

Her hands grip the wheel now for dear life.

Their cousin, RAYMOND, opens the gate as Belinda chases after the family of bears.

BELINDA

Lucinda, you fool!

OUT THE GATES, and into the streets.

RIVER

(points)

Straight.

Lucinda continues.

BELINDA

(fading)

Fool!

Louis, in the backseat, wails.

FRANK

Shh- shh...

HAZEL

Here, let me have him.

Frank hands Louis into Hazel's arms. She rocks him.

His crying wanes into silence.

RIVER

That went well, didn't it?

The adults chuckle.

RIVER

Luce, I just hope-

River knocks on Lucinda's shoulder.

RIVER

I hope you know what you're doing.

Lucinda keeps her gaze on the open road.

LUCINDA
Oh, I know one thing.
(glares)
Fuck this place.

River grunts, leans on his arm by the windowsill.

3 EXT. AIRPORT - LOCOS - DAY

3

The 4x4 pulls up to the loading zone.

Lucinda, Frank, and the kids pile out. Then their
SUITCASES:
- Two stickered smalls.
- Two plain larges.

River hugs Lucinda. They hold it as the wind blows.

LUCINDA
You're not calling. I will. Okay?

RIVER
(nods)
Just get outta here before Mom kills
you.

He pats her back in encouragement.

Then shakes hands with Frank.

RIVER
So long, HR.

Frank CACKLES. River pats him on the back, too, before
hopping into the driver's seat.

LUCINDA
(eyes welling)
Good luck.

RIVER
(sad smile)
And good riddance.

And just like that, River disappears behind the pillars.

Lucinda nods at Frank. He grabs the luggage. They BOOK IT.

4 INT. AIRPORT - LOCOS - DAY

4

By the time they enter the airport, Louis's crying has
subsided.

Lucinda marvels at its beauty, tracing the interior. Its infrastructure is strangely human, with trusses, poles, supports, escalators of all different speeds and levels.

Bears of all kinds walk around: other grizzly bears like them, black bears, kermodes, cinnamons, polars.

The occasional REPTILIAN or AVIAN.

Montage:

- The family weighs luggages.
- Up the escalator.
- Through TSA.

Passports: LUCINDA EDENTI, FRANK BELMONE.

5 INT. AIRPORT - LOCOS - NIGHT

5

The family lands on the airport seats, exhausted, waiting for boarding.

Hazel, holding a bougie plastic container with a half-eaten trout burrito, tugs at her mother's shoulder.

HAZEL

Mom, is Auntie Marlene meeting us there?

On the realization, she frowns. Hands Louis over to Frank. Then LUNGES for Lucinda, clutching her for dear life.

A picture slips out of Lucinda's pocket.

It's a family photo of her sisters MARLENE and YVETTE.

They're by a pool with Hazel, splashing, having the time of their lives. All captured on a single sheet of plastic.

Lucinda reaches for the picture, but can't without alerting her. She returns the hug, urgently TAPS Frank's shoulder. Frank hides it before Hazel can notice.

LUCINDA

No, but she won't need to. I promise.

HAZEL

But Mom!

Hazel shakes her head. Lucinda hugs tighter.

Photo hidden, Frank turns to Louis.

FRANK

(sighs)

Oh, Louis...

He kisses Louis on the forehead, as Louis drifts to sleep.
The stillest thing in here.

6 INT. AIRPLANE - LOCOS - NIGHT

6

A dog takes the nearest seat. Frank drops the affection.
Cabin lights ON.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT
Prepare for departure, 8:05!

Frank's watch: 8:00PM. He closes his eyes.

On a different aisle, seated with Hazel, who's tapping the
airplane screen transfixed, Lucinda closes hers.

The jets turn on. It SPEEDS. The cabin shakes with the
rupture of inexperience. Lucinda holds it all in. Now she
clings to her daughter.

The plane takes off.

7 INT. LUCINDA'S HOME - TULANES - NIGHT

7

Couch.

It's their new pull-out sofa. Her and the kids on it.

Frank on the floor. Paperwork for school on the table. A
single, new family photo of them on unpacked luggages by
the fridge.

Lucinda sits, taps Frank's shoulder, lightly this time.

He takes her place.

8 EXT. LUCINDA'S HOME - TULANES - NIGHT

8

The backyard door slides open to an empty plot of soil,
itching to be watered.

Lucinda sits on the ledge next to the fence and unwraps
her blanket.

Staring at the open sky, no longer smoggy.

And the moon, clear as day. So clear.

But her eyes drift down to a photo. It's the same photo
from the airport. In her other hand, a LIGHTER.

She flips it on, her eyes lighting with it, and brings it
to the PHOTO-

She can't.

She falls forward, failing herself. Slams her thigh. And after one shaky exhale-

Buries it under the weeds.

CUT TO BLACK.

YEARS LATER:

9 INT. GYM - TULANES HIGH SCHOOL - NIGHT

9

Sudden reggae trap, loud, stereo.

A gum-stained basketball court. Animals of different sizes, patterns, colors, species, classes, mashed between sets of bleachers.

It's nothing like Locos.

The DJ on an elevated platform.

DJ
Class of 2026!

The crowd roars.

One grizzly bear stands out: an OLDER LOUIS.

He's not just older. He's big, well-fed, wearing a pink flipped snapback, white shirt, rose shorts, jumping, trashing, moshing.

LOUIS
Woo!

CHUGS a snuck-in bottle.

LOUIS
End of the fucking world, let's go.

Clinks it with several classmates. The night blurs into SILHOUETTES, different species, all making out with him.

Drink, kiss, drink, kiss, drink, kiss-

Dry hurling in the men's.

10 EXT. FRONT ENTRANCE - TULANES HIGH SCHOOL - NIGHT

10

Students burst out the DOORS of the gym, Louis alone.

He massages his temple, opens his eyes to his group of buddies in a corner:

- WILLY, a weasel.
- BAXTER, a badger.
- FERELL, a ferret.

He charges them, TACKLING THEM with affection.

LOUIS
(taunting)
Look at you, thinking about pussy.

BAXTER
Hell have you been?

LOUIS
(whispering)
I was making out with
Seneca-fucking-Lowell, that's what!

The boys cheer. SCORE.

11 EXT. PUBLIC PARK - TULANES - NIGHT

11

All sitting on SCRATCHED long plastic picnic tables.
They're under a patio roofing. Graffiti on the floor,
playground, out-of-order water fountains.

Ferell lights a smoke.

Louis flips the ringer back on. It's a text from MOM:

"where are you?" "come home."

His smile fades into discontent.

He brings it to his face, writes "Park," holds on send-

Second-guesses. Tries different places. "School."
"Grillzy's." "Hazel's BF's."

Nothing comes up. He sighs. Nods. He scrolls up and lands
on a message: "You gonna watch?"

Deletes it.

LOUIS
Right, boys. Ready for tomorrow?

The boys lean in. Out from his pocket, Louis grabs a
CRUMPLED PAGE. It's a TOURNEY-STYLE setup with names. On
the page is clear signaling: bboys, krumpers.

This is a HIP HOP COMPETITION.

LOUIS
You take Yani out, advance to round
two. I take Eve.

BAXTER
Then one of us snags the prize
money, splits it, bada bang, bada
boom-

FERELL

Brother, that's if we make it.

Willy, done with his hit, hands it over to Baxter, then Ferell.

LOUIS

Sorry. Responding to my fuckass Mom.

WILLY

Miss Porridge can wait. Hello!
Yoo-hoo!

Willy keeps shoving it. The boys BLOCK HIS VISION. They piss him off until-

LOUIS

Alright, alright! Gimme five seconds!

Despite the boys, he drafts and redrafts and redrafts, but he's hardly able to get a word in. His concentration fades into chuckling, which fades into laughter.

He SNAGS the joint off Willy.

The boys brings out their phones. All recording. Louis brings it to his mouth.

Takes a DRAG. Longer than any of them they ever could.

Then falls to the ground, half-wheezing, half-hacking. The group bursts back into cackles, as the video goes up online.

The text goes unanswered.

Instead, the boys roughhouse, hollering away, a bubble of joy in the eerie suburban quiet.

12 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - NIGHT

12

Door closes. Louis does his best, but CRASHES into a shelf.

HAZEL

Mm...

His eyes widen. To his right, cramped on the couch:

OLDER HAZEL, clearly years out of high school, unlike him.

Half-shirtless with scraggly hair. On top of her: HER BOYFRIEND, another grizzly.

Louis slaps himself sober.

He tiptoes to the kitchen. FRANK snores. Professionally.

CREAK.

The fridge opens to a TUB OF LEFTOVER ICE CREAM waiting to be downed. Louis painstakingly extracts it in the quiet.

Despite a loud SNORE, he doesn't flinch.

The door closes TO THESE 3x4 PHOTOS, MAGNETIZED:

- Hazel's high school graduation.
- A friend's wedding.
- Beach trip.
- Childhood friends.
- Finally, a photo of them from ALL THOSE YEARS AGO, on the couch.

Louis smiles at it. But his eyes trail upward to the bills.

Water bill, trash, PG&E, rent.

Inside his own bedroom:

- Posters of rock and hip hop bands.
- Figurines and popular characters.
- Hung-up shirts and viral merchandise.

A stack of POSTERS under the bed for the comp.

But Louis ignores it all. He unlids the tub, takes out his controller-

13 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - DAY

13

Only to never press play.

HAZEL (O.S.)
(muffled)
I've been keeping it real cute!

Louis juts awake. He glances at the tub.

It's melted.

He creaks open the door, rubbing his eyes.

On the table is Lucinda's phone, texts with Louis still unanswered.

Unpaid bills on the table. CITY SERVICES priced at \$100. A wad of cash nearby.

An OLDER LUCINDA in the kitchen, clearly pissed at the whole ordeal, waving her hands in disapproval.

Frank watching the TV. Passive and uninterested.

Hazel grabs her resume, RUTHLESSLY LISTS IT OFF, but stumbles over key words.

HAZEL
Soft skills. Workplace
collaboration, cultural competence.
(annunciated)
"Competence." Organizational tools-
parenthesis- calorie budgeting
spreadsheet- parenthesis-

LUCINDA
(snags it)
Give me that.

Lucinda RIPS the paper in half.

LUCINDA
I don't wanna hear this anymore.
Focus on getting the part, don't
prove to me you can save. Everyone
knows how to save.

HAZEL
Not on calories. Look at you,
wasting paper. Take your own advice.

Lucinda flips the salmon like she's never been happier to flip anything else in her life.

HAZEL
You hear me, hag?

Louis grimaces. Too much.

Frank whips around, glaring.

Hazel turns, STORMS out of the house. On the way:

LOUIS
(yawns)
Sup.

HAZEL
Hey.

Her boyfriend nods at Louis on the way out, chill throughout the entire argument.

DOOR SLAMS.

Frank turns to Lucinda, one elbow over the couch.

FRANK
That went well. "Get off your ass,
Frank." Oh, but work starts at 8AM.
"Then do something useful!"

Smug, Frank holds up a check. RENT. He FLICKS it.

FRANK
Wow, look at that!

Lucinda smirks, shakes her head.

LUCINDA
Did I tell you I've always wanted to
strangle an ex-corporate jerk-off?

FRANK
You're very overwhelming, you know that?

Louis's eyes widen. He knows he's next. He creeps back into his room, closes the door- brings the tub up to his mouth, SLATHERS the melt in-

FRANK (O.S.)
Louis!

LOUIS
Mrgh...

A stain on his shirt.

14 INT. FRANK'S CAR - TULANES - DAY

14

Louis hops in the car, his dad watching the VIDEO FROM LAST NIGHT.

Shit. Louis grabs the handle, thrusts it open, bolts-

But Frank SNAGS him back into passenger's seat.

Clears his throat.

Silence.

Does it again.

LOUIS
I plead the fifth.

FRANK
You're not getting away with this one.

Frank pulls Louis's ear.

LOUIS
Ow, ow ow ow ow-

It's one button away from SENDING TO LUCINDA.

FRANK
We're understaffed today, and it's
the weekend. What do you know?

LOUIS
Dad, I graduate in like- can you
save this for-

FRANK
We could really use an extra hand!

LOUIS
Okay! Okay! Okay!

Frank releases the ear, spins the keys around his finger
in glee.

FRANK
Right then!

Frank soft-slaps his kid. Inserts, turns the keys, foot on
the accelerator-

But for a moment, he stares at it. Stunned, as through
remembering something from long ago.

His expression softens as he stick-shifts out of the
driveway.

15 INT. HAZEL'S BOYFRIEND'S CAR - TULANES - DAY

15

The ripped resume's in the back.

But Hazel printed a SPARE ONE. She glances at the resume,
top to bottom. Stares at the address line for too long.
Especially the city:

"TULANES."

After a deep sigh, she drops it.

She's now in business attire, combing hair. Nods at her
boyfriend, who's counting hard cash in the driver's seat.

HAZEL
(offers)
Dax.

With care, he takes the comb off her hands. Then kisses
her on the forehead.

Out she goes.

16 INT. GRILLZY'S - TULANES - DAY

16

People eating branded FAST FOOD with that tacky bear logo
on it.

Eyes on her body. She's so tall she can't hide her frame if she tried to. So she keeps that sheet of paper close to her chest.

Then pulls back her shoulders in confidence.

17 **INT. BACK OFFICE - GRILLZY'S - DAY**

17

The hiring manager sits with cupped hands.

RABBIT

We had a pig before you came in.

What a dig. A low one. She maintains a poker face. It doesn't slip.

The rabbit notices. He softens his gaze.

Shakes her hand.

HAZEL

Hazel Belmone.

RABBIT

Let's jump right into it. When was the last time you championed teamwork?

HAZEL

Once, in high school, I was paired with a mouse, for a group project. It was a language course.

Disdain on "language," like she resents the word.

HAZEL

We had to write our final essay on the ethics of mammalian project development for the fashion industry.

Rabbit nods. She's giving him something to work with.

HAZEL

So we split our work into two stages. First, we interviewed people- sample size of 40-

RABBIT

Small.

HAZEL

(nervous chuckle)

RABBIT

(quiet)

Keep going.

Hazel retreats for a moment. Puffs out her chest again.

HAZEL

Then we presented our findings,
which was that 66% of large and
small animals reported they don't
fall within standard clothing sizes,
even when markets brand them as size
"L" or "S."

Rabbit shifts, uncomfortable. But not the bad kind of
uncomfortable that pushes you out the door. It's the
discomfort of recognition, in an office room, in the
middle of an industrial nowhere.

HAZEL

Our teacher brought our speech to a
public panel, where we reached over
200 people, and they signed
petitions and lobbied Tulanes'
government to introduce higher
sizing of fabric textiles in
boutiques and upcycle shops.

Rabbit shifts again. Hazel takes a deep breath-

RABBIT

Gonna stop you there, I have what I
need.

Hazel's face drops.

RABBIT

We'll call in the next 12 hours.

Hazel's breathing quickens, so she stifles it.

18 EXT. GRILLZY'S - TULANES - DAY

18

She storms out of the shop, fanning her face with her
resume, hyperventilating on autopilot.

HAZEL

(HR voice)

We'll call in the next 12-

She CRASHES OUT at the air.

HAZEL

12- fucking- fuckity- fuckfuck-

Sighs.

As her gaze lifts to sky, she sees:

A billboard with an AIRPLANE AD on it.

Her breathing halts for a moment.

Then determination revives on her face- GETS MOVING.

But a poster-filled lamppost swings by her.

She comes to a stop.

PICKS one off.

It's the poster of the competition, down on 6th West Street. Louis himself on the graphic. \$200 for the winner.

She stares, bewildered, as though seeing this for the first time-

HAZEL

Huh.

Before hopping into her boyfriend's car.

19 INT. DOWNTOWN - TULANES - DAY

19

Louis stares at old, rugged buildings in passerby.

Frank stares at the keys, transfixed- then at his kid. All grown up.

His gaze, already soft, eases further.

LOUIS

I got that thing at 6, by the way.

Pause. Frank snaps back to the road. Raises his eyebrows, as if to say, spit it before you lose me.

LOUIS

The comp thing.

FRANK

You have more important things than "comp." Especially to your mother.

LOUIS

Splitting it four ways. I win \$50 if I make it. Kind of important.

FRANK

But did you respond to her, kid?

Clouds and blue on the mirror. Louis squints his eyes, staring into it, shutting out the question.

LOUIS

Earlier, I asked her to come. "Just a hobby," she said.

Frank smacks his lips.

20 EXT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - DAY 20

Lucinda DIGS UNDER THE WEEDS.

21 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - DAY 21

She's now in the kitchen, wiping down the OLD PHOTO while on phone with a client.

Most lights are off. All that's on are the stark-blue underhead cabinet lights, and an orange lamp on the table.

LUCINDA

18th.

Calendar says GRAD PARTY on a Saturday, GRADUATION on Sunday. Both for Louis.

Today is only the 1st.

LUCINDA

Sunday the 25th I have something.

(taps fingers)

Okay. Just call when you have availability.

Phone call ends.

She sits down, finishes dusting off the photo. Stares at it. Stuffs it into her purse.

Then walks back to their landline. After a slow punch-in:

RIVER (V.O.)

Uncle River, message at the tone,
bla bla bla.

Lucinda chuckles quietly. BEEP.

LUCINDA

Yearly check-in. Hazel has an interview today. Louis still has to text me back.

She stares at her purse.

LUCINDA

I booked another client this month, well, tried to, and I miss...

Her eyes move to the fridge. Then the same motion as Louis's. Up to the bills.

LUCINDA
We need money, River. Bad.
(bites her lip)
Sorry to break it to you.

She moves the receiver down.

MATCH CUT TO:

22 INT. UPCYCLE SHOP - TULANES - DAY

22

Frank takes his hand off the shop's landline.

Fur everywhere in tubs. Coat hangers, tailored dresses, lint rollers.

TEXTILES along the wall. They're massive. In the process of being expanded.

Frank fastens on his name tag. To his left, Louis.

LOUIS
Sort by color, length, width. I
haven't forgotten. Now where are
those gloves?

Lazily searching, he turns to face Frank. A pair of BLACK RUBBER GLOVES land on his face. He sends off a bothered look, then slips them on.

RING!

Tired customer. Frank puts on a nice big service smile.

Tub of fur on the counter. Frank measures. 4.5CM, 0.4MM, brown, thick.

Frank counts cash. It's a \$0.98 reimbursement for the donation.

A measurement poster on the wall says BROWN'S A COMMON COLOR. Frank silently, slowly, cheekily lifts a finger to point right at it, a sly smile spreading.

Customer snatches the fee, storms out of the shop.

SLAM.

IN THE BACK:

Louis sorts through fur, sized by length in CM, width in MM, color, condition. Flies all around. He shoos them. But aside is a photo of FRANK AND HIS WORK FRIENDS.

The photo's lit in DINGY and yellow, no more flattering than an iodine streetlamp.

FRANK (O.S.)
Callbacks?
(laughs)
Your mom should rip apart more of
those resumes, let the adrenaline
carry you through the interview.
(laughs, then-)
N- no, look, I was joking- Ah, shit.

He appears around the corner. Knocks. Comes in.

FRANK
(rubs forehead)
I can interview you.

No response means no in this case.

LOUIS
Lemme guess, you're gonna be honest
with me for once?

Louis turns around, raises his eyebrows, confused.

FRANK
What do you want to be when you
graduate?

LOUIS
(squinting)
Now?

FRANK
It's the question your mom has been
asking since we got here.

Louis stares at the tub.

LOUIS
Not you.

He raises his eyebrows, back to his dad, smirks.

But his dad's not having this one- wipes his nose. Heads
to the front.

Louis's smile fades. He follows, carrying the tub.

In goes the water. Then the chemicals.

The two disinfect submerged strands of brown.

LOUIS
I like doing my shit. I freestyle.
That's worth something. Can you show
up for that?
(silence)
You wanna go?

Their faces warp and distort in the reflection.

FRANK

I have my show at 7 and the water
takes so long to warm up.

(quieter)

Are you doing another one of those
next week? Next month?

He shakes his head.

LOUIS

When are you coming to something,
Dad?

FRANK

I'm coming to graduation.

Louis lowers his eyes, nods.

He checks his watch. It's 5:40. Not even he has a chance
to shower. But he focuses. He pours the remaining solution
and they finish incorporating it.

A pile of CURED, WET fur on the counter. They stare at the
soggy thing.

LOUIS

(nods)

Time's up. See you later, alligator.

FRANK

In a while, crocodile.

They fist-bump. He bolts out.

23 EXT. UPCYCLE SHOP - TULANES - DAY

23

Louis tosses his latex gloves, unties his hair, sprints
down uneven pavement. Slow to quick.

24 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - DAY

24

The door WHAMS open. But it's not Louis, it's Hazel. She
rounds the corner, then sits. Hands on the table in fists.

Lucinda's halfway down her purse. She takes her hand out.

HAZEL

You were saying.

LUCINDA

Mm.

HAZEL

Mom, I was thinking that with my own
income, I can move out.

Lucinda glances up at her.

LUCINDA
You won't have to split rent if you
live here.

HAZEL
I'm not sleeping on the couch.

LUCINDA
Then have your own room. Deal?

Hazel flicks her hair back.

A PHONE CALL.

Lucinda and Hazel tense up. Hazel takes it.

RIVER (V.O.)
Hello?

After hearing it, Lucinda freezes- SNAGS it out from
Hazel's hands.

LUCINDA
W-We're not interested in spam
calls. Bye.

RIVER (V.O.)
Luce, how's Hazel?

LUCINDA
She's not here. Stop calling this
number! I'll call!

Lucinda SLAMS the receiver shut. Infuriated at first- then
drops at the bewilderment on her daughter's face.

HAZEL
What was that?!
(shaky)
You. Give me th-

Hazel SNATCHES the phone, but it's already off the line.

HAZEL
Why, Mom?! What the hell? Why? Why?!

Hazel grabs a piece of paper and CHUCKS it at Lucinda. She
runs out the door.

LUCINDA
Hazel, that wasn't your callback!

HAZEL
Then who was it?! You didn't even,
like-

Lucinda freezes. She won't divulge.

Hazel just smiles and nods, sarcastic, eyes welling- then whips around, PISSED beyond belief.

While ripping Lucinda's car keys off the rack, she misses the family photo falling out of the purse IN PLAIN SIGHT.

Lucinda stuffs the photo back in- but Hazel's already well out the front door, VAULTING into her boyfriend's car.

It stuns Lucinda. For a moment, she stands there, shocked.

No. She doubles back for the keys, but Hazel took them-

Defeated, she buries her head into her hands.

Notices the piece of paper on the floor.

Unwraps it.

It's the freestyle comp.

Frank appears at the front door.

FRANK

...Luce?

25 EXT. 6TH WEST STREET - TULANES - DOWNTOWN

25

Louis's cold hard sneakers hit the floor before beads of sweat do.

He plants his hands on his thighs. Slows down.

LOUIS

(panting)

Hah! Kill me now!

There's a street at the end. It's glowing. There's loud music blasting. But it's just way too far. He comes to a stop.

He falls to his knees, practically heaving. Too tired to cry, too hurt to keep going.

But a car pulls by.

HAZEL

Hey, Louis! Save your breath!

He glances up, his eyes lightening.

He LANDS in the backseat. Hazel turns around, elbow on the headrest.

He opens his mouth, but he's winded.

HAZEL
 You're welcome. Don't thank me, just
 focus on the competition.
 (she points)
 See it?

Boyfriend nods. Switches to third gear. FLOORS IT.

A wide grin spreads across Louis's face as he's INJECTED
 into his seat.

VROOOM!

The car skids on the lane. Doors open. Hazel lags behind
 as Louis handshakes and daps up the contestants. His
 buddies Ferell, Baxter, Willy, first, then at least a
 dozen others.

LOUIS
 (panting)
 Before you ask me why I almost
 bailed on my own comp, just know, I
 have fur all over my fur.

BAXTER
 Hot.

WILLY
 Is it gonna mess you up, though?

Louis shrugs.

FERELL
 Then get out there and play the
 game.

LOUIS
 (salutes)
 Yes, boys!

HOST
 We're beginning round one! Circle!
 Circle! Circle!

Crowd hypes them up. Hazel and her boyfriend cheer.

The host CRANKS the slider, taps play.

The boys are ALL IN:
 - Ferell with toprock.
 - Willy runs the worm.
 - Baxter pop and lock.

They trick, impressive, but their opponents hit them
 harder.

Each new round is more unhinged than the last.

In this mishmash of tricking and combos, the attendees- including Louis and Hazel- lose themselves in an explosion of color and chaos. Beaming smiles, spit splattering from fangs as they CHEER AND FORGET. Streetlamps counter moving spotlights. Party cups in the air.

Hazel and her boyfriend lock hands.

The host grabs the battlers' hands.

He LIFTS the winner's hand-

Ferrell doesn't advance.

WILLY
(glares)
Come on...

But Willy goes down second.

Baxter third.

The music on stereo crescendos to a still, then:

HOST
Louis!

LOUIS
Finally.

He DASHES in as music floods and pours into every sensation.

As though the tiredness FLUSHES FROM HIS BODY in a single moment, he's on the floor, tricking, spinning, carefully planting every hand. Every finger, every goddamn claw.

The ear Frank nearly tore up BRUSHES across the concrete, narrowly missing a real tear.

His body reflects in his cracked phone screen, off.

He flips back to top, gets ready to TRICK-

HOST
3! 2! 1!

Time's up. But that's not what Louis hears.

The competition muffles into a simple scene:

26 EXT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - DAY

26

Louis RUSHING across the weeds, once a kid, his parents waving a flag, cheering him on.

27 EXT. 6TH WEST STREET - TULANES - DOWNTOWN**27**

Louis comes to, stunned. His eyes trail up to his sister and her boyfriend cheering.

He smiles.

MOMENTS LATER:

Louis stands in apprehension, holding hands with the host and his opponent.

Host throws up his opponent's hand.

Louis is sadly ELIMINATED.

The last of his friends to be so.

Past the crowd, on a folding table by the DJ: a stack of cash, untouched. Not theirs any longer.

28 EXT. APARTMENT - TULANES - NIGHT**28**

The boys all walk across the street.

Louis, pensive, takes off his hat.

The boys ruffle his hair.

BAXTER

Next time?

LOUIS

(chuckles)

If you're all still around.

He stares up at the skyline. Past downtown, across the high-end mountain homes, along the stars.

But his ear twitches. They turn to:

A FELLOW COMPETITOR: SENECA, black cat, light on feet.

SENECA

I've seen you around the comps.

(points)

You. You're great, you surprise me.

The boys nudge Louis.

LOUIS

You too. I dig your bandana.

Louis offers a handshake. His boys rattle on his shoulder, excited. He tries to keep it 1:1 with her, without so much as a smirk.

LOUIS

Louis.

SENECA

Seneca. We met in a hot, sweaty gym.

He pauses- then his eyes widen in recognition. Drops the handshake; hands on his own hips.

LOUIS

You do projects?

SENECA

Mainly music. I've been showing around what I make. Could use a fresh set of ears.

Louis brings out his social media profile. Seneca punches in hers- follows. Just then, a text from MOM:

"don't stay out too late."

"love you son <3."

Seneca stares at "<3," then back to Louis.

And for a moment, Louis is frozen in place. He grabs the phone quietly.

29 INT. GRILLZY'S - TULANES - NIGHT

29

Hazel and Louis sit across each other. Louis's boys and Hazel's boyfriend talk halfway across the restaurant.

His phone on the table.

HAZEL

Wanna know where I interviewed today?

OUT COMES THE MANAGER.

It's the rabbit from earlier. He walks out the door, but catches Hazel's eye on the way out.

Instead of amazement, Louis scratches his head in concern.

LOUIS

Hazel, really? Here?

Hazel's smile drops.

HAZEL

I did STAR and everything.

Hazel leans on her fist, as if to disengage completely. But Louis pats on the table.

LOUIS
I don't think this place is out of
your league.

HAZEL
Then where do I go?
(shakes head)
Wait until you get the diploma,
Louis. I'm telling you.

They chew on their burgers.

HAZEL
Dad offered you an interview?
(bites lip)
Wish I got one.

Louis stares at his texts. How he left his mother on
delivered, his dad on read.

He slowly picks up his phone, types three words.

"Grillzy's, home soon."

Then one final symbol.

"<3."

Sends.

30 INT. LUCINDA'S HOUSE - TULANES - NIGHT

30

Inside the kitchen is Lucinda, working through bills.
Frank beside her. The TV on, unattended.

They brush hands.

Louis and Hazel open the door.

Down the foyer, the yellowed walls, the wooden
floorboards, plastic shutters, dusty shelves and altars
they go.

Their mother turns around, parts her quivering lips,
baring white-toothed fangs.

LUCINDA
There's something you should know
about my mother.
(bitter smile)
She still thinks I owe her
everything.

Louis and Hazel tense up.

LUCINDA

And I've realized you two are
leaving the house more, whenever you
want, wherever you want. If I'm
right, this whole thing starts the
way it ends.

She takes a long inhale before finishing the thought.

LUCINDA

So if you want to leave someday- if
there's anything you ever want to
tell me- from now on, please tell
me.

HAZEL

I'll consider your deal about my
room. But I'll keep applying.

LOUIS

And I'll figure out how to make real
money. I'll be in the loop. Soon.

Lucinda stops. Waits. Nods. An honest nod.

The phone rings. Hazel dashes over, stopped by Lucinda.

LUCINDA

Just wanna make sure.
(into receiver)
Hello?
(quieter)
Yes, this is Hazel's mom.

She hands it to Hazel.

Hazel paces, coiling the cord around her finger.

Then looks up at her family.

HAZEL

(excited)
Does Tuesday work?

The family RUSHES for her, HUGGING HER CLOSE-

As the muffled sound of an airplane SOARS on TV.

They call it a moving picture.

CUT TO BLACK.